# I Liked It Less

For three years, I kept the drumsticks I broke. I wrote the date on each one with a marker and, when I remembered, what had killed it: a split tip, a worn shoulder, a crack down the shaft.

I do not know which pair I used the night I spent more than half an hour arguing about thirty-second notes.

I was in eighth grade, and our band was preparing 青い、濃い、橙色の日 for the school New Year's show. We had two electric guitars, bass, keyboard, vocals, and me on drums. During the instrumental section, I wanted to keep the dense pattern from the original arrangement. It had quick figures and fills everywhere—the sort of part that gave my hands plenty to do and was simply fun to play.

One of the guitarists wanted to simplify it.

I thought he wanted to make the song boring.

We argued for more than half an hour. I had several reasons, and at the time they felt like the same reason. The original was written that way. I could play it. The pattern fit.

None of those things seemed trivial to me. I had spent enough time practicing complicated figures that being able to play one cleanly felt like a reason to keep it. If the notes fit inside the bar, and if my hands could get through them, I did not see why they should disappear.

Eventually I slapped the page and said, “The original does it like this. This is what the audience wants.”

He stopped arguing.

“You’ll have fun onstage,” he said, “but everyone out there is just going to hear drums smashing over the singer.”

I was annoyed.

We recorded a run-through.

Through the headphones, I could still hear the singer. That was almost worse. The voice was technically there, but the feeling in the line kept getting buried. Every time it seemed to have some room, another fill arrived.

I took off one side of the headphones.

Nothing I had played sounded obviously wrong. I could still hear why I had wanted each figure there. Individually, they worked. I still liked the little rush of one fill opening into another, the density of having almost no empty space under my hands.

But the song did not need all of them.

The electric guitars had more room when I stopped answering every opening with the drums. Their part could carry more of the emotion of the instrumental section instead of competing with something else for the same space. The arrangement felt less crowded. There was more distance between things, and because of that, more shape.

Some of the thirty-second-note figures became sixteenths. I shortened several fills and deleted others.

I liked the new part less.

It was less fun under my hands. There was less movement around the kit, fewer places where I got to do the thing I had spent all that time practicing.

The band sounded better.

At the performance, I still preferred the denser version as a drum part. The simpler one did not suddenly become more satisfying to play just because I had accepted the reason for it. There were stretches where my hands were doing less, and I knew exactly what I could have put back into them.

But the feeling onstage was different from the satisfaction of playing something difficult by myself.

The guitars had room to open up. The song felt more layered because not every layer was trying to announce itself at once. Sitting inside the arrangement, I could feel that it was more coordinated, more settled.

I was comfortable with the way the band sounded.

I liked how the band sounded more than I liked playing my part.

I still preferred the denser version as a drum part. I just no longer preferred it as the drum part in that song.

I still like complicated fills.

This is apparently not a phase.

Even now, I sometimes add something because I know I can play it. Then we record the song, I listen back, and there it is: a fill I enjoyed playing much more than I enjoy hearing.

Sometimes I keep it.

Sometimes I cut it in half.

Sometimes I delete it and remain mildly offended.

The broken sticks are still around somewhere. A few have writing I can barely read now. I cannot tell which ones came from that New Year's show, and I do not remember exactly what I wrote on them.

I remember the part I took out.

It would still be more fun to play.